Muslim Filipina TOWNS Awardees

This article documents a distinguished group of Muslim Filipina leaders honored by the. These awardees come from different Bangsamoro communities, including the Maranao, Maguindanaoan, Tausug, and Yakan, reflecting the region's diversity in leadership and public service.

They have contributed to education, governance, peacebuilding, social work, and journalism, shaping both regional and national conversations.

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Ethnicity Representation Summary

Ethnicity	Number of Awardees
Maranao	4
Maguindanaoan	2
Tausug	1
Yakan	1
Mixed / Mindanao-based	1



Muslim Filipina TOWNS Awardees

Name	Details
Emily **Marohombsar**	1977 • Education • Maranao
Marlene H. **Tamano**	1986 • Education • Maranao
Bai Rohaniza **Sumndad-Usman**	2019 • Education & Peacebuilding • Maranao
Atty. Sha Elijah Biruar **Dumama-Alba**	2025 • Peacebuilding & Governance • Maguindanaoan
Mayor Sitti Djalia **Turabin-Hataman**	2025 • Governance • Yakan
Samira Ali **Gutoc**	2019 • Peace Advocacy • Maranao
Deputy Minister Nur-Ainee **Tan-Lim**	2025 • Public Service • Tausug
Noraida Adang Abdullah **Karim**	2013 • Social Work • Maguindanaoan
Jamela Aisha Martinez **Alindogan**	2025 • Journalism • Mindanao-based, Mixed Heritage

Editorial Note on Representation

BangsamoroPedia and the Notable Muslim Filipinos initiative aim to document notable individuals across the entire Bangsamoro, not limited to any single ethnolinguistic group. The distribution shown above reflects the available and verifiable profiles included in this article, and does not represent a fixed or exclusive selection. As more qualified individuals from different communities are documented, representation is expected to broaden further.

Education and Academic Leadership

Emily R. Marohombsar (1977)

- **Field**: Education
- **Ethnicity**: Maranao

Emily Marohombsar, born in Ganassi, Lanao del Sur, was the first Muslim woman to receive the TOWNS award. She later became the first female President of the Mindanao State University system.

Her leadership helped sustain MSU as a space for social integration in Mindanao. She also served as part of the government peace panel negotiating with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front.

Her career marked an early breakthrough for Maranao women in academic and national leadership.

Marlene Hofer Tamano (1986)

- **Field**: Education
- **Ethnicity**: Maranao

Marlene H. Tamano focused her career on strengthening education in the Bangsamoro. Coming from the Hofer family of Cebu/Zamboanga Sibugay and the Tamano family of Tugaya, Lanao Sur, she worked on curriculum development that integrates Islamic values with national standards.

Her work helped create a more grounded and identity-based learning experience for Moro students.

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman (2019)

- **Field**: Education and Peacebuilding
- **Ethnicity**: Maranao

Bai Rohaniza Sumndad-Usman founded the Teach Peace Build Peace Movement, an initiative that promotes peace education among children in conflict-affected communities.

Through her programs, tens of thousands of learners have been introduced to peace-centered values at an early stage.

Peacebuilding, Law, and Governance

Atty. Sha Elijah Biruar Dumama-Alba (2025)

- **Field**: Peacebuilding and Governance
- **Ethnicity**: Maguindanaoan

Atty. Sha Elijah Dumama-Alba serves as Attorney General of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao.

She played a key role in drafting foundational laws of BARMM, including the Administrative Code, Civil Service Code, and Electoral Code. Her work supports institutional stability in the region.

Mayor Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman (2025)

- **Field**: Governance
- **Ethnicity**: Yakan

Mayor Sitti Djalia Turabin-Hataman has served in both national and local leadership roles, including as Executive Director of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos and as a party-list representative.

As Mayor of Isabela City, she focused on socio-economic development while supporting Yakan cultural preservation, particularly traditional weaving.

Samira Ali Gutoc (2019)

- **Field**: Peace Advocacy
- **Ethnicity**: Maranao

Samira Gutoc is a former legislator in the ARMM Regional Legislative Assembly. She gained national attention after resigning from the Bangsamoro Transition Commission during the declaration of Martial Law in 2017.

She founded the Ranao Rescue Team, which provided assistance to civilians affected by the Marawi Siege.

Public Service and Social Work

Deputy Minister Nur-Ainee Tan-Lim (2025)

- **Field**: Public Service
- **Ethnicity**: Tausug

Nur-Ainee Tan-Lim serves as Deputy Minister of the Ministry of Social Services and Development in BARMM.

Her work focuses on improving service delivery in remote areas, especially in Sulu, and promoting transparency in aid distribution.

Noraida Adang Abdullah Karim (2013)

- **Field**: Social Work
- **Ethnicity**: Maguindanaoan

Noraida Karim has led humanitarian efforts in conflict-affected areas, particularly in Maguindanao.

Her approach emphasizes conflict-sensitive resource management, ensuring that aid delivery does not aggravate local tensions such as clan conflicts.

Journalism

Jamela Aisha Martinez Alindogan (2025)

- **Field**: Journalism
- **Ethnicity**: Mindanao-based, mixed heritage

Jamela Alindogan is a journalist known for her field reporting in conflict zones, including the Marawi Siege and other major events in Mindanao.

She is also the founder of Sinagtala, which supports women and children affected by conflict through livelihood and safe-space initiatives.

Representation and Impact

These awardees reflect the diversity of the Bangsamoro, representing multiple ethnolinguistic groups across the region.

Their work highlights the growing role of Muslim Filipina leaders in shaping education, governance, and peacebuilding, both within Mindanao and at the national level.

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